

Monica

A Haggadah for Tonight

Welcome & First Cup of Wine

Moto lights the candles and raises a glass.

MOTO:

Welcome, everyone. Tonight we tell an old story about people who were enslaved and then got free. It is a story we keep telling because it keeps being relevant. People are still enslaved. People are still fleeing. People are still told they don't belong in their own bodies, their own lands, their own forests.

So we gather around this table, with wine and salt water and matzah that tastes like cardboard — because nothing says 'celebration' like a cracker with no yeast — and we remember. And we refuse to look away.

Let's begin with the first cup of wine — or grape juice, no judgment.

Everyone raises their glass.

Everyone: Blessed are You, Source of all life, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Drink the first cup.

Karpas — Greens & Salt Water

DAISY:

We dip a green vegetable in salt water. The green is for spring — things growing, life returning. The salt water is for tears. There's no shortage of tears this year. We hold both at once: the green and the salt.

Everyone dips their greens in salt water and eats.

Yachatz — Breaking the Matzah

Moto breaks the middle matzah in two.

MOTO:

This is the bread of affliction. Our ancestors ate it in Egypt. We break it in two — one half stays here, one half gets hidden for later. The fancy word is afikomen. The practical word is 'leverage,' because a certain six-year-old is about to negotiate hard for it later.

Moto hides the afikomen. Ollie, pay attention. Or don't — your call.

The Four Questions

The youngest person at the table asks four questions. That's Ollie.

OLLIE:

Why is tonight different from all other nights?

On all other nights we eat bread or matzah. Why tonight only matzah?

On all other nights we eat all kinds of vegetables. Why tonight do we dip them in salt water?

On all other nights we don't dip our food at all. Why tonight do we dip twice?

On all other nights we sit however we want. Why tonight do we lean?

The Story — We Were Slaves

DAVID:

Short version: we were slaves in Egypt. Pharaoh was not a good guy. He feared the Israelites because there were a lot of them and they were different, and throughout history, that combination has made powerful people do terrible things. It still does.

God heard the suffering and sent Moses — a guy who didn't even want the job — to say, 'Let my people go.' Pharaoh said no. Repeatedly. Because people with too much power almost always say no the first time. And the second. And the ninth.

The Story — Plagues and Freedom

YOUR PART:

So there were plagues. Ten of them. They were bad for everyone — that's how plagues work. The Egyptians suffered, and we don't celebrate that. We diminish our wine for each one, because our freedom came at a cost to others. Every liberation does.

After the tenth plague, Pharaoh finally let the people go. They left so fast the bread didn't rise — hence the matzah. They crossed the sea. And then came the hard part, which is the part that always comes after freedom: figuring out what to do with it.

Next: Zoe

The Ten Plagues

ZOE:

As we name each plague, we spill a drop of wine — because our joy is diminished by the suffering of others, even when those others opposed us. If that principle held up more often in the world, we'd be in better shape.

Remove a drop of wine for each plague.

Everyone: Blood. Frogs. Lice. Flies. Cattle disease. Boils. Hail. Locusts. Darkness. Death of the firstborn.

ZOE:

We might also name some modern plagues: the destruction of forests and wild places. Children bombed in their homes. People denied medical care for who they are. Wars that serve no one who fights in them. We don't spill wine for these. We spill effort. At least we try.

Dayenu — It Would Have Been Enough

TAI:

Dayenu is a song about gratitude — 'it would have been enough.' Which is a generous way to look at things. If God had only taken us out of Egypt but not split the sea — dayenu. If God had only split the sea but not given us the Torah — dayenu. It's a practice of noticing what you have. We could use more of that.

Fair warning: this song is catchy. You will be humming it while doing dishes later.

Everyone sings. Even if you don't know the tune, just follow along.

Everyone: Da-da-yenu, da-da-yenu, da-da-yenu, dayenu dayenu!

Everyone: Da-da-yenu, da-da-yenu, da-da-yenu, dayenu dayenu!

Next: Ryan

The Three Symbols

RYAN:

Rabban Gamliel — a rabbi, not a character from Lord of the Rings — said you haven't done your duty at the seder unless you've discussed three things:

Pesach — the lamb bone. It represents the sacrifice our ancestors made. We don't sacrifice lambs anymore, so here's a bone on a plate looking dramatic.

Matzah — the flat bread. Our ancestors fled in such a hurry they couldn't wait for dough to rise. It also represents humility. A cracker that knows its place.

Maror — the bitter herb. Horseradish, usually. It represents the bitterness of slavery. Eat enough of it and you'll understand suffering on a personal level.

Everyone raises their glass for the second cup.

Everyone: Blessed are You, Source of all life, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Drink the second cup.

Matzah, Maror & the Hillel Sandwich

MOTO:

Time to eat the ritual foods. First, the matzah.

Everyone: Blessed are You, Source of all life, who brings forth bread from the earth.

Everyone eats a piece of matzah.

Now the bitter herb. Dip the maror in the charoset — that's the sweet brown stuff — and eat it.

Everyone eats maror with charoset.

Now make a sandwich: matzah, maror, charoset, matzah. This was Hillel's idea. Two thousand years old, and still the best sandwich recipe involving zero leavened bread.

Everyone eats the Hillel sandwich.

The Meal!

Time to eat! After dinner, we'll come back for the afikomen and the closing.

After the Meal — Afikomen & Elijah's Cup

MOTO:

Ollie — and anyone who helped — it's time to find the afikomen.

The afikomen is found. Negotiations ensue. Dessert matzah is eaten by all.

Now we open the door for Elijah, the prophet who is said to visit every seder. Elijah represents hope — the hope that the world can still get better. Some nights that feels like a heavy lift. We open the door anyway.

Someone opens the door. A moment of silence.

Miriam's Cup

DAISY:

Miriam was Moses's sister. She watched over him in the river. She led the people in song after they crossed the sea. The tradition of Miriam's Cup — filled with water — honors women and all the people whose work keeps communities alive but rarely makes it into the official story. We see you.

Everyone raises Miriam's cup of water.

The Third Cup & Closing

Everyone raises their glass for the third cup.

Everyone: Blessed are You, Source of all life, who creates the fruit of the vine.

Drink the third cup.

MOTO:

That's our seder. It was short. The matzah was dry. The horseradish cleared some sinuses. But we sat together, told an old story, and remembered that freedom isn't something anyone gets to take for granted. Not then. Not now.

Next year, may the world have less to grieve. Next year, may more people be safe in who they are. Next year, may the forests still stand.

Everyone: Next year in Jerusalem! Next year, may all people be free!

The seder is over. Refill your wine. You've earned it.